Bird Opening

ECO A02-B21 | 28 named lines | Flank openings (English, Reti, Bird, KIA)

In one sentence: Flexible flank openings control the center with pieces and avoid early theoretical battles.

Memory pattern: Fianchetto, control d5 and e5, then pick the center.



Main line: 1.f4 e5 2.fxe5 d6 3.exd6 Bxd6 4.Nf3

Key ideas

1. Control d5 and e5 with pawns on c4 and pieces on f3 and c3.
2. Fianchetto the king's bishop (g3, Bg2) for long-diagonal pressure.
3. Choose a center after seeing Black's setup: d4 or e4.
4. Transpose to Queen's Gambit, Catalan or Sicilian-style structures.
5. English: reversed Sicilian ideas with extra tempo.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.32** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best: Qe7.

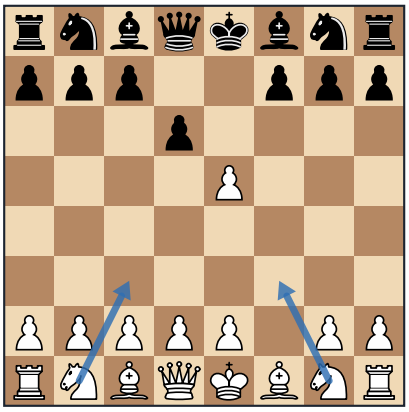
The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Control d5/e5 with pieces and keep the centre flexible (Reversed Sicilian, Reti, King's Indian Attack). Transpositions are common.
2. Where does my king go?	Castle short; g3/Bg2 is a safe shelter.
3. Best minor pieces?	Bg2 and Bb2 on the long diagonals, knights c3/f3, breaks with d4/e4.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Choose a centre after seeing Black's setup; expand with b4 or d4; attack with e4/Ne5.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants a favourable centre; Black wants to claim the centre with ...e5/...d5 or symmetrical counterplay.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.f4 e5 2.fxe5 d6 3.exd6 Bxd6 4.Nf3

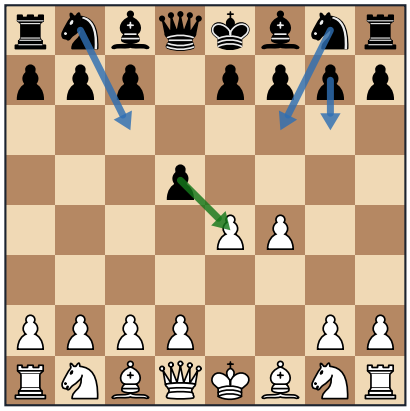
Move	Why it is played
1. f4	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
1... e5	Take the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. fxe5	Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
2... d6	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
3. exd6	Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
3... Bxd6	Develops the bishop to d6.
4. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.



After 1.f4 e5 2.fxe5 d6

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

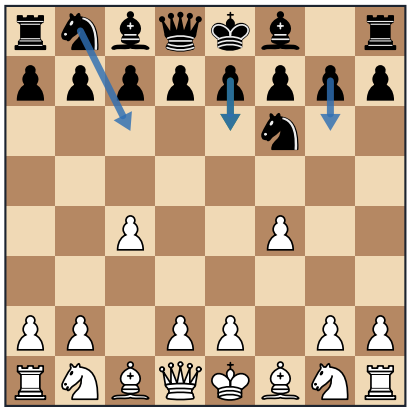


Position after the line

Williams Gambit A03 | 2 lines

`1.f4 d5 2.e4`

Stockfish: **-1.45** (clearly better for Black, depth 17). Best next move: dxe4.
What to look for: e5 (take the center); Nf6 (develop); d5 (hit c4)

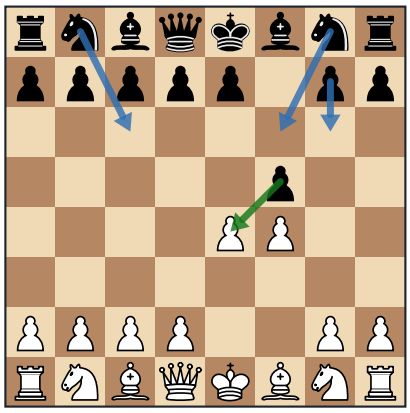


Position after the line

Mujannah A02 | 1 lines

`1.f4 Nf6 2.c4`

Stockfish: **-0.38** (slightly better for Black, depth 18). Best next move: e6.
What to look for: e5 (take the center); Nf6 (develop); d5 (hit c4)

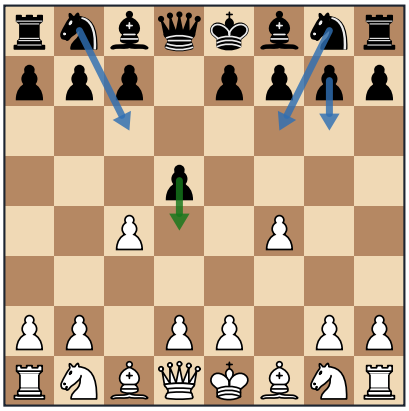


Position after the line

Wagner-Zwitersch Gambit A02 | 1 lines

`1.f4 f5 2.e4`

Stockfish: **-0.21** (equal, depth 17). Best next move: fxe4.
What to look for: e5 (take the center); Nf6 (develop); d5 (hit c4)

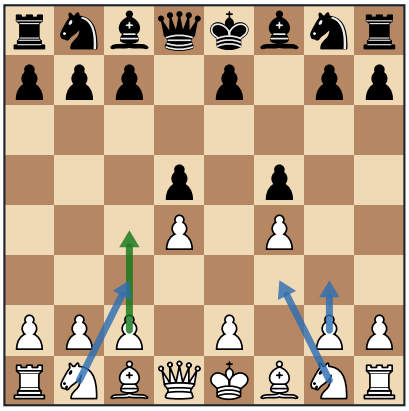


Position after the line

Sturm Gambit A03 | 1 lines

`1.f4 d5 2.c4`

Stockfish: **-0.85** (clearly better for Black, depth 16). Best next move: d4.
What to look for: e5 (take the center); Nf6 (develop); d5 (hit c4)

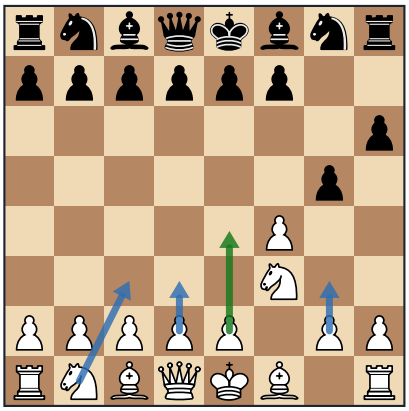


Position after the line

Double Duck Formation A02 | 1 lines

`1.f4 f5 2.d4 d5`

Stockfish: **+0.15** (equal, depth 20). Best next move: c4.
What to look for: c4 (control d5); Nf3 (develop); g3 (fianchetto)



Position after the line

Hobbs-Zilbermints Gambit A02 | 1 lines

`1.f4 h6 2.Nf3 g5`

Stockfish: **+0.95** (clearly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: e4.
What to look for: c4 (control d5); Nf3 (develop); g3 (fianchetto)

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Flank openings are about flexibility, not speed. Make sure you know the main transpositions and what structures you want, then choose moves accordingly.

Why play it

Flexible flank openings control the center with pieces and avoid early theoretical battles.

Typical mistakes

- Being too passive and letting Black take the center for free.
- Playing d3 and e4 without a plan for the queenside pawns.
- Neglecting development while chasing a fianchetto.

Typical tactics and traps

- Early Qb3 or Qa4 pins that win the c4 or d5 pawn if Black is careless.
- Tactics on the long diagonal against b7/g7.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Balanced, flexible endgames with minor advantages for the better-placed bishops.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Bird Opening (all lines)** — A02
  `1.f4`
  - **Dutch Variation** — A03
    `1.f4 -> 1...d5`
    - **Dudweiler Gambit** — A03
      `1.f4 d5 -> 2.g4`
    - **Batavo Gambit** — B21
      `1.e4 c5 2.f4 d5 3.Nf3 dxe4`
  - **From's Gambit** — A02
    `1.f4 -> 1...e5`
    - **Bahr Gambit** — A02
      `1.f4 e5 -> 2.Nc3`
    - **Langheld Gambit** — A02
      `1.f4 e5 -> 2.fxe5 d6 3.exd6 Nf6`
    - **Lasker Variation** — A02
      `1.f4 e5 -> 2.fxe5 d6 3.exd6 Bxd6 4.Nf3 g5`
    - **Lipke Variation** — A02
      `1.f4 e5 -> 2.fxe5 d6 3.exd6 Bxd6 4.Nf3 Nh6 5.d4`
  - **Hobbs Gambit** — A02
    `1.f4 -> 1...g5`
  - **Horsefly Defense** — A02
    `1.f4 -> 1...Nh6`
  - **Myers Defense** — A02
    `1.f4 -> 1...b5`
  - **Mujannah** — A02
    `1.f4 -> 1...Nf6 2.c4`
  - **Sturm Gambit** — A03
    `1.f4 -> 1...d5 2.c4`
  - **Wagner-Zwitersch Gambit** — A02
    `1.f4 -> 1...f5 2.e4`
  - **Williams Gambit** — A03
    `1.f4 -> 1...d5 2.e4`
  - **Double Duck Formation** — A02
    `1.f4 -> 1...f5 2.d4 d5`
  - **Hobbs-Zilbermints Gambit** — A02
    `1.f4 -> 1...h6 2.Nf3 g5`
  - **Lasker Gambit** — A02
    `1.f4 -> 1...e5 2.fxe5 f6`
  - **Platz Gambit** — A02
    `1.f4 -> 1...e5 2.fxe5 Ne7`
  - **Schlechter Gambit** — A02
    `1.f4 -> 1...e5 2.fxe5 Nc6`
  - **Batavo-Polish Attack** — A02
    `1.f4 -> 1...Nf6 2.Nf3 g6 3.b4`
  - **Lasker Variation** — A03
    `1.f4 -> 1...d5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.e3 c5`
  - **Siegener Gambit** — A02
    `1.f4 -> 1...e5 2.d4 exd4 3.Nf3 c5 4.c3`
  - **Swiss Gambit** — A02
    `1.f4 -> 1...f5 2.e4 fxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.g4`
  - **Williams-Zilbermints Gambit** — A03
    `1.f4 -> 1...d5 2.e4 dxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Nge2`
  - **Thomas Gambit** — A03
    `1.f4 -> 1...d5 2.b3 Nf6 3.Bb2 d4 4.Nf3 c5 5.e3`

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.f4 e5 2.fxe5 d6 3.exd6 Bxd6 4.Nf3
```

Plan chain

White	c4 -> Nf3 -> g3 -> Bg2 -> O-O
Black	e5 -> Nf6 -> d5 -> c5 -> g6

Three rules to remember

1. Fianchetto, control d5 and e5, then pick the center.
2. Choose a centre after seeing Black's setup; expand with b4 or d4; attack with e4/Ne5.
3. White wants a favourable centre; Black wants to claim the centre with ...e5/...d5 or symmetrical counterplay.

Pawn structure in one line

Control d5/e5 with pieces and keep the centre flexible (Reversed Sicilian, Reti, King's Indian Attack). Transpositions are common.